

Adobe Forward Deployed Engineering: Defining Field Product Managers

Summary

Forward Deployed AI Product Management, which I will refer to as Field AI PM in the rest of the memo, is a new role that continues to evolve with AI. In my most recent experience, I captured five features that Adobe and any company aiming to build a Forward Deployed Team should consider.

- Field AI PM is different from SaaS PM starting from the objective. The Field AI PM solves a new AI problem with a customer where no existing products apply. The SaaS PM (excluding founders) optimizes an existing product.
- The ideal Field AI PM combines consulting polish, founder mindset, and technical know-how. In particular, the hands-on AI know-how cannot be skipped, because customers will ask broad AI questions and expect technical answers.
- Solving for every capability in one Field AI PM results in a null set. Hiring a diverse group of Field AI PMs with spikes combined with smart assignments, coaching, and cross-pollination worked exceptionally well at C3.
- The ideal partner to the Field AI PM, the Forward Deployed Engineer, needs to echo the founder mindset and resourcefulness. Initial UI by week 3 and demo by week 6 while solving unforeseen challenges are the new standard.
- The future of the Field AI Team is defined by the velocity of AI innovation. The team will need to adapt to video models, environment models, world observation models, and embodied AI. At the same time, solving new AI problems with customers will only increase in demand.

The Field AI PM and SaaS PM Comparison

The table below highlights the differences between Field AI PM and SaaS PM. In many ways, the Field AI PM works more similarly to pre-PMF startup founders.

Dimension	Field AI PM	SaaS PM
Objective	Solve the customer's new AI problem statement.	Optimize existing products or product space.
KPI	NPS, conversion (next round of 'funding'), and customer-specific KPIs.	ARR, MAU, retention, etc.
Mindset	Pre-PMF startup that must obtain the next round of 'funding.'	Risk-adverse, consensus-building, incremental.
Core Skills	Relationship management, intense problem solving, including technical know-how.	Heavy process, presentations, documentation, and research.
End of Cycle	Work with Platform or Base teams to generalize the customer-specific AI product.	New round of aligning objectives and adjusting roadmaps.

Each customer engagement feels like a startup seeking its first user. The Field AI PM must prove measurable impact to customer stakeholders to earn the next "funding tranche." The Field AI PM is empowered to pivot working with the customer to hunt for value if the initial idea fails. In extreme cases, the Field AI PM could fail to achieve impact but convince the customer to continue "funding" based on interim results and a trust-based relationship. Therefore, the role is more individualistic and dynamic than most corporate roles.

Lastly, Field AI PMs could become SaaS PMs (happened at C3) to manage generalized, base products. However, the reverse is more challenging.

The Ideal Field AI PM

The ideal Field AI PM combines consulting polish, founder mindset, and technical know-how. At C3, I translated these attributes into twelve skills across four categories to drive coaching and performance. Below is a modified version for the Adobe context.

Skills (in order of importance):

1. Stakeholder Management

- Customer relationships: Build trust-based customer relationships with leveling based on customer seniority.

- Internal relationships: Build internal relationships that translate to less internal friction and ultimately better customer results.
- Executive communications: Self-explanatory, leveling based on audience levels.

2. Problem Solving

- AI/ML technical know-how: Hands-on-keyboard experience in non-production environments (e.g., Jupyter Notebooks) to explore data, test models, and speak credibly about architecture and feasibility.
- Business acumen: Learn and understand the customers' industry economics and operations.
- Creativity: Combine AI and product design to deliver differentiated solutions.

3. Process Management

- Team management: Create a productive and enjoyable day-to-day team working environment, which can be challenging under customer pressure.
- Timeline management: Manage milestones, executive reviews, and final delivery.
- Agile development: Operate effectively in agile, hybrid customer settings.

4. Adobe Knowledge

- Business: Know the Adobe customers and the creatives space.
- Platform: Know the full capability and limitations of the Adobe AI Stack.
- Language and culture: Self-explanatory.

Remi, Varun, both of you asked me whether the Field AI PM should code. My short answer is yes, but in the non-production context. This means the Field AI PM can explore the data, test models, and build mock-ups without engineering support. In the age of AI Code Assistants, PMs claiming to be passionate about software must code.

In addition, customers expect the Field AI PMs to be AI experts and will ask questions unrelated to the engagement. Unfortunately, AI is a non-intuitive field, and answering basic questions without hands-on-keyboard experience is challenging. I interviewed hundreds of candidates, and few could answer a simple: “how do neural nets work?”

Building the Team

Solving for every capability in one Field AI PM results in a null set, so the real candidates will have a subset of the skills and learn the rest. I found hiring for “spikes” worked better than hiring for “flatter” skill profiles. In most cases, customers needed to be impressed with exciting outputs instead of mundane meets-the-bar. Assigning the right “spikes” while

covering for weaknesses delivered those exciting outputs. The more diverse team coached each other, energized each other, and could handle more challenging situations.

The successful candidates are hybrid strategic-technical talent. Three ideal hiring profiles, in order of fit:

1. MBB Consulting with Technical Training – e.g., McKinsey senior engagement manager with a PhD in mathematics.
2. Technical SaaS PM with Good Presence – e.g., Google PM with an approachable, laid-back style. Needed coaching and support on handling difficult conversations.
3. System Integrator with Good Intrinsic – e.g., Accenture consultant with an adaptable problem-solving mindset. Needed coaching on bias towards action and support on difficult conversations.

Despite my emphasis on technical know-how, stakeholder management is the most important skill to hire for. Technical know-how is surprisingly quick to train in the right environment; however, stakeholder management requires rare experience handling difficult conversations.

The Ideal Forward Deployed Engineer (FDE)

This memo is focused on Field AI PMs, so I will not focus on FDEs. However, during fast paced customer co-development, the FDE needs to have the same founder mindset and resourcefulness. UI/UX and standard data models are commodities that AI Code Assistants can build with minimal intervention. The FDE needs to iterate weekly with initial UI by week 3 and demo by week 6 while balancing code quality. In addition, the FDE may need to solve wide ranging customer-specific issues, such as local npm registries, BACnet integration, air-gap, etc.

The Future of Field AI PM

The future is bright for Field AI PMs, especially for Adobe driven by several trends.

1. Frontier AI innovation accelerates towards video, environment, world observation, and embodied AI instead of language models.
2. Innovation is occurring far faster than the translation to economic value, creating a pipeline of work for Field AI PMs.
3. The speed at which ideas can become software is shockingly fast, driving a premium for core problem solving and know-how.